The Thief of Tears

By Jeffrey Hatcher

Lights up on Mac, an attractive woman between the ages of 35 and 45. Mac wears black. Lots of sparkling rings on her fingers.

CHARLIE: (Pg 32) *(we pick up in the middle of a imagined talk show)* How'd ya' get your *start* in - well - I guess we'd *have* to call it – heck . . . *corpse-robbing,* right?

MAC: Right you are, Charlie. *Weel,* it was like this: I had just moved from Stockbridge to L.A., I was broke. A friend of mine died, a bad death. I hadn't been to a funeral in a long time, and they'd put me in charge of accessorizing him for the viewing, but his wrists were so small, his watch wouldn't fit, so I put it in my purse. It wasn't until three days after the funeral that I realized I still had the watch. I was gonna give it back ... but it was a Rolex in a rough week. And anyway give it back to whom? So I rationalized keeping the watch ... then selling it ... then finding ways to do it again. It's kept me in high five figures for eight years now. Never caught, knock on wood.

CHARLIE: But gosh is there anything you *won't* steal?

MAC: Sure. A wedding ring. A friendship ring. A decoder ring. There are limits. *(Beat – to audience)* (Pg 34) Let me go back. (Pg 31) Thomas Wolfe once wrote: "You can't go home again." *(Beat.)* Thomas Wolfe was a putz, of *course* you can go home again, they *make* you go home, *all the time* - <u>*endlessly*</u> . But this time is different. I'm going to *get* something from *this* trip. *(Beat)* (Pg 30) [So . . .] She's dead. My grandmother, Nettie James is dead. This is my moment. My destiny has called me. (Pg 29) I've been stealing jewelry off corpses for years, Grandma'll be a cinch.

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INTRODUCTION

Meet Mac -- a coffin robber, a pretend mourner who can bend down to kiss the deceased goodbye and stand up with two ruby earrings in her closed mouth. Today she is at the wake of her own grandmother with more than mourning in mind. See, Grandma has a ring . . . but coming home again may be more than Mac bargained for. Thief of Tears by Jeffrey Hatcher

MAC: (Pg 33) I arrive over the river and through the woods to grandmother's funeral. Inside the parlor, the first viewing has begun. (Pg 34-38) They're all acting - well - they're acting as if someone has *died.* Nettie James was 103 years old. This funeral has been in rehearsal so long it's had replacement casts. *(Pause)* Let me go back. *(takes photo from her purse)* In the photograph I've brought with me from L.A. a beautifully coiffed woman in her sixties holds the hand of an equally beautifully-coiffed five-year-old girl with red eyes from crying. It's 1963, and I'm *not* going to go to the beauty parlor. I'm screaming in the back of the big blue Packard, and my grandmother has decided to calm me down by taking me into the big department store, The Hub. She holds my hand, and when we enter, hundreds of shop clerks rush to greet us, bending, grovelling, rubbing their hands. They give her presents. Something especially important seems to come from Morton Lincoff from jewelry – something wrapped in a box.

GRANDMA: You see? If you're nice to people, they'll give you things. Tell you what: you be a good girl today when you get your hair done, and Nettie'll *give* you what's in this box.

MAC: And she opens it. Inside is a beautiful tear-shaped ring. It seems to sparkle with every jewel in the planet. I've never seen such color, so many facets, such light. I will do *anything* to get this ring. So I *am* a good girl, and I *do* calm down, and I *get* my hair done. And when it's all over,

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and we're back at Norton Place, I ask my grandmother, "So where's my present?" And Nettie says

GRANDMA: Oh, that was just something I *said.* You can't always get what you *want.*

MAC: *And the ring goes on <u>her</u> finger.* Let me go back. . . The family returns to the parlor where the second viewing has begun. The crowd around the coffin has gone on a coffee break, so I make a bee-line for the casket. I peer in at my grandmother. A voice nearby murmurs:

MOURNER: She looks good.

MAC: I nod. (She looks like Stalin.) Her hands are folded, touching, one over the other. She always wore the dinner ring on her right hand, aaannnd ... that's the hand I cannot see. How am I going to find out if she's wearing that ring?

DAD: Mac, we have a problem. Nettie's new will left instructions specifying certain pieces of jewelry she wanted to be buried with. The funeral home won't take responsibility for the pieces overnight. Their policy is to have the family do the *physical removal* from the body and keep the jewels at home until morning. Now, your mother is in no state to do it. We'd like *you* to do it, Mac. *(Beat.)*

MAC: *(falsely)* Oh. I *couldn't.* *(strategically reconsiders)* All *right,* sure. *(She looks at the audience as if to say "This is where you came in." and speaks to audience)* I've been stealing jewelry off corpses for years, Grandma'll be a cinch. I go to my grandmother. I remove the jewelry. I very deftly *flip* her left hand off her right. There is *no* tear-shaped dinner ring. Her fingers are bare. I pat her down like a cop at the airport. It's not there. Nothing. *(Pause)* In a daze, I go back to Norton Place very alone. I'm in the pink room of my grandmother's home, in the pink bed that's been mine since I was a child.

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In the darkness, I dream of Jack. Jack in our house in Stockbridge, holding hands with Paul and Lainie at his side. (Pg 34) Let me go back.

JACK: (Pg 38) Why can't you love the littlest things? The things you can hold in your hand. What do you *want* from this world?

MAC: There are so many things you can't get or hold on to. Like color, and facets, and light. And then - in the dream - Jack takes my hand ... and says:

JACK: Is that why you tried to kill yourself? *(Pause.)*

MAC: Yes. I left our bed and I went into the garage, and I sat in the car in the cold, cold night and turned on the ignition. I *tried*. Didn't work out the way I'd planned. *(Pause.)* (Pg 34) Let me go back. (Pg 38) The next morning ... I call the airport to get the soonest possible flight back to L.A. My bags are in the BMW outside the funeral home. *Inside* ... I'm at my post for the third and *final* viewing ... I notice a tiny bald man. It's Morton Lincoff from The Hub! He's ancient now - like Yoda. And he says to me:

MORTON: Where is that husband and those two kids?

MAC: (Pg 39) *(at if by rote)* I am not married now. My husband never fixed the kitchen door.

MORTON: *(puzzled, but continues)* You know, I remember you coming into the store with your grandmother - must have been thirty years ago - the day you were going to get your first hair done .. Your grandmother had come in to pick up a ring your grandfather had me design. Beautiful thing. The one she's wearing right now."

MAC: You mean the, the *tear-shaped* ring?

MORTON: Yes! Your grandmother had sent it in to be cleaned before she died. I just give it back to Mister Funeral. Your grandmother, she wanted she

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should be buried with it, and who are we to argue with the dead?

MAC: It's there. It's *there.* Why shouldn't I take it? It was, by rights - it was by rights . . . *mine.* And I need - I *want* - (Pg 34) *(shakes off her thoughts)* Let me go back. (Pg 39-40) The service is about to begin. The family is to pay its last tributes. One by one. *(Pause)* It's worked for me a billion times, it'll work for me again. No one dare stop the emotional grand-daughter from her final embrace. I grip the side of the casket. I lean my face to hers. I kiss her cheek - and place my hand upon her hand. Her ring is harder to remove than I had hoped, as if the finger's swelled. I pull. Nothing. I twist. Nothing. I do not want to break her finger. It is an occupational hazard, and I don't want my grandmother to be my first "snapper." And then I look down. Because Nettie's eyes - my grandmother's eyes - are wide open and watching me.

MAC: Grandma?

GRANDMA: Why have you been lying to my old friends about that family of yours? Tell Grandma where that husband of yours is and my two great-grandchildren.

MAC: (Pg 34) Let me go back. (Pg 40) I look for my family - my *family!* - and there's no one in the room! *(shouting) My husband never fixed the kitchen door! . . . . (long pause, the quietly to the audience)* (Pg 41) And after I fell asleep in the garage, I finally woke up at the hospital in Stockbridge and I asked where is my husband, where is my daughter, where is my son ... they explained to me ... that because the kitchen was attached to the garage, and because the kitchen door had never been fixed, the door had opened, and the air from the garage had drifted into the house and into the bedrooms and my family - my husband, my children, my littlest things ... it had killed my family ... while I slept. *(begins working on the ring again)*

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Let me go back. Let me go back! *Let me go back!* And the ring comes off! *(Beat.)*

MAC: I did not die the day I tried to kill myself. They buried my family before I had a chance to touch them, hold their hands one more time. Jack's wedding ring. Lainie's friendship ring. Paul's decoder ring. But I am alive, and my grandmother's ring is cold to my touch. It is not what I want or need. (Pg 42) *(Pause. Mac kneels and begins to remove her rings, until by the end, of the next speech, she looks like a mourner from the old country, dressed in black.)*

In Stockbridge, Massachusetts, where I lived for years, there is a place where my other family is buried. I have not yet visited them. But I know the way there. (long pause) Tears freeze in the cold. When they hit the stone they break into a shattering of colors and facets and light. I gather them close to me, and I am warm like a thief in the night. *(Slow fade end of play.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
IL State Finalist
Ohio State Qualifier
SD State Finalist

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